CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: Rare earths nationalisation threatened · Navy shower-camera probe · $3b aged care plan sunk · Peters bypassed Luxon on UN vote · NZ election nears amid aid fight

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,728	0.7013	13,760	0.5620
0.00%	+0.70%	+0.56%	+0.34%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Resources Minister Madeleine King has left open nationalising a Perth rare-earths company after China-linked investors defied Canberra's divestment orders, testing the foreign-investment screening regime.
2. New Zealand's Winston Peters confirmed he did not notify Christopher Luxon before New Zealand became one of only two countries to abstain on a UN pandemic-preparedness declaration.
3. A three-day, multinational rescue off Solomon Islands brought all 73 passengers of the ferry MV Awka ashore safely, with French and Australian aircraft airdropping supplies and a Vanuatu medical vessel joining the operation.

TOP STORIES

TRADE-ECONOMY

Resources minister leaves door open to nationalising rare earths firm

Resources Minister **Madeleine King** has left open the possibility of nationalising a Perth-based critical minerals company after several China-linked investors defied federal government orders to divest their stakes. The standoff tests Canberra's foreign-investment screening regime in a sector central to diversifying critical minerals supply away from China.

per ABC News (Stephen Dziedzic): "Rare earths company could be nationalised as China-linked investors fail to divest"

AU-DEFENSE

Hidden recording device found in navy ship's female quarters

Military police are investigating after a recording device was found on October 11 in a female-only cabin aboard HMAS Leeuwin, docked in Cairns. Senator **Jacqui Lambie** told the Senate she had received a letter alleging the device was in "shower facilities" and that footage "may have been uploaded online" before discovery; she is drafting a private member's bill on Defence Force standards.

per ABC News: "Recording device found in women's 'shower facilities' of Australian navy ship" · also SMH (Matthew Knott): "Hidden camera found in female showers on navy ship"

AU-POLITICS

Senate ambush sinks Labor's $3 billion aged care plan

The Coalition, the Greens, One Nation, and the crossbench combined in the Senate to kill Labor's over-65 health rebate plan, sinking a *$3 billion* aged care package. Health Minister **Butler** has vowed to reintroduce the bill, while the ABC reports the related private health insurance changes were effectively thrown out of parliament by the same combination.

per SMH: "Butler vows to bring back health rebate bill after Senate ambush sinks $3b aged care plan" · also ABC News: "Government fails to secure support for beleaguered private health bill"

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

Peters bypassed Luxon before NZ's UN pandemic abstention

Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** said signing the non-binding UN declaration on pandemic prevention, preparedness, and response would have been "problematic," rejecting suggestions the abstention was performative. New Zealand was one of only two countries to abstain at the UN General Assembly on Tuesday. Peters confirmed he did not notify **Christopher Luxon** or the health minister this week, though he says he told Associate Health Minister **Simeon Brown** "weeks ago."

per RNZ: "Morning Report: Winston Peters and John Campbell in fiery clash over UN document"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY Canberra belatedly joins criticism of US sanctions on ICC · ABC News

Australia has added its voice to international criticism of U.S. sanctions aimed at the International Criminal Court, ABC News reports, after an extended silence. The belated alignment puts Canberra alongside other partners pushing back on Washington's campaign against the court.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY Wong calls Palestinian election delay 'deeply disappointing' · ABC News

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** called **Mahmoud Abbas**'s decision to postpone Palestinian legislative and presidential polls until 2027 "deeply disappointing." Abbas blames Israeli attacks, settler violence, and humanitarian conditions; Israel calls that explanation a "ridiculous lie." France has called for elections to be held immediately.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY Boyer Lecture warns Australia's strategic boldness lacks a political home · ABC News

In this year's Boyer Lecture keynote, **Sam Roggeveen** argues the post-Cold War assumption that China would accept uncontested U.S. leadership in Asia "is clearly not how things are turning out." The lecture frames Australia's strategic debate as unsettled rather than resolved.

STAT OF THE DAY

27%

Labor's primary vote in a DemosAU MRP poll that still shows it winning a House majority

The projection illustrates how Australia's electorate geography can preserve a governing majority even as primary vote support erodes, a dynamic shadowing Albanese's standing against Taylor and One Nation.

The Conversation AU

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Hong Kong-linked firm seeks to buy Australian military shipyard

Australian Defence Magazine reports that a firm linked to Hong Kong is seeking to purchase an Australian military shipyard. The report, carried only as a headline, gives no further detail on the yard involved or the proposed terms of sale.

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Fiji minister defends MPs' pay as salary debate reignites

Fisheries and Forestry Minister **Alitia Bainivalu** posted an "honest" Facebook defense of ministerial salaries, citing traditional and community obligations, and divided opinion online. An ordinary Fijian MP earns *over 600 percent* more than a full-time minimum-wage worker; backbenchers received a 138 percent pay rise in May 2024 before a mandatory 20 percent cut in April 2026 amid the fuel crisis.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solomon Islands ferry passengers rescued after three days adrift

The ferry MV Awka, carrying *73 passengers* and crew, arrived under tow three days after losing power off remote Temotu Province. French and Australian aircraft airdropped supplies and the government patrol boat Gizo joined the rescue, alongside the Vanuatu-based medical vessel HELPR-1.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC

PNG police seize weapons cache linked to international syndicate

Papua New Guinea's police chief said the seizure of a high-powered weapons cache highlights the threat posed by transnational criminal syndicates exploiting the country for illicit firearms movement, RNZ Pacific reports.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG MP presses defence minister over recruitment saga

Finschhafen MP **Rainbo Paita** challenged Defence Minister **Elias Kapavore** over the decision to resume PNG Defence Force recruitment before parliament received findings from an independent investigation into the earlier, controversial recruitment process.

TUVALU · ABC PACIFIC

Tuvalu's climate minister rejects 'failure' verdict on Pre-COP31

Tuvalu's Climate Change Minister **Maina Vakafua Talia** pushed back on criticism that last week's Pre-COP31 meeting was a failure, ABC Pacific reports, as the Pacific looks ahead to COP31 negotiations.

REGIONAL · RNZ PACIFIC

Forecasters warn of elevated cyclone risk across northern Pacific

Earth Sciences New Zealand, with MetService and the University of Newcastle, forecasts *seven to eleven* named cyclones in the Southwest Pacific this season, with elevated risk for Samoa, Tokelau, and parts of Kiribati. New Caledonia and Vanuatu face a normal-to-reduced risk, while Fiji and Tonga are forecast near-normal activity.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ

New Zealand's Peters disputes National's foreign aid math

New Zealand's Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** has disputed a National Party claim that foreign aid rose *26 percent* since 2021, with his office calling the figure incorrect and citing an inflation-adjusted 10 percent rise instead. National wants to redirect the savings into $604 million for new medicines while "fully protecting aid to the Pacific"; ACT proposes deeper cuts to 2017 levels, saving about $238 million a year.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Te Tai Tonga race wide open after Ferris's expulsion from Te Pāti Māori

New Zealand's largest electorate, covering the entire South Island, is contested anew after incumbent **Tākuta Ferris**'s expulsion from Te Pāti Māori. Ferris won the seat in 2023 by *2,824 votes* over Labor's **Rino Tirikatene**; none of the candidates can fall back on the party list, making the electorate their only path to parliament.

NZ-DEFENSE · RNZ

NZDF tenders for $20 million polar surveillance drone

The New Zealand Defence Force is seeking a *$20 million* polar surveillance drone able to fly up to 100 nautical miles from the naval ship Aotearoa in the Southern Ocean. The tender, closing next month, foreshadows further drone purchases under the 2025-29 Defence Capability Plan, whose technology accelerator funding so far falls short of the plan's $100-300 million target.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Housing groups urge Kāinga Ora to halt pre-election state house sale

Ten Wellington housing and social service groups have written to New Zealand's state housing agency Kāinga Ora, urging chief executive **Tracey Taylor** to halt the deadline sale of *36* empty Strathmore homes, set for October 21, two weeks before the November 7 election.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Albanese and Taylor meet more often as One Nation gains ground

Anthony Albanese and **Angus Taylor** met at Parliament House on Monday as the crossbench raised concerns about a possible Labor-Coalition deal on artificial intelligence, SMH's Paul Sakkal reports. The more frequent contact comes as One Nation support presses on Labor's primary vote.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Shoebridge tells Ukrainian community not to 'burn your bridges' with Greens

New Greens leader **Shoebridge** urged the Ukrainian-Australian community not to alienate his party during a tense meeting over the Greens' opposition to military aid for Ukraine, SMH's Matthew Knott reports. The Greens set defence "red lines" this month, including refusing arms transfers to Ukraine and curtailing the U.S. alliance.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Chalmers faces two-year fight over $40 billion trust tax overhaul

Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** faces a nearly two-year campaign against his proposed trust tax reforms, which businesses warn will cause accounting turmoil, even as he insists the changes make taxation fairer. The overhaul is projected to raise *$40 billion*.

AU-POLITICS · THE CONVERSATION AU

DemosAU poll: Labor wins House majority on just 27% primary vote

A new DemosAU MRP poll projects Labor retaining a clear majority of House seats on a primary vote of only *27 percent*, with support for One Nation appearing to have eased. The seat-vote gap underscores how Australia's electoral geography can insulate a governing majority from primary vote erosion.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

FOI shows Albanese made no submission to Bondi antisemitism inquiry

Freedom-of-information documents show **Anthony Albanese** made no submission and no preparations for the Bondi antisemitism inquiry, The Australian reports. The disclosure adds to political pressure on the government over its handling of the inquiry's establishment.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Australia tables bill reserving up to 20% of LNG exports for local market

The government has tabled legislation forcing LNG exporters to reserve up to *20 percent* of production for the domestic market, Bloomberg reports. The bill follows warnings from gas producers of market paralysis as the reservation scheme takes effect.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

BHP cuts 300 jobs at Australian iron ore mines as costs rise

BHP has cut *300* workers from its Australian iron ore operations as costs rise, Bloomberg reports, the latest sign of pressure on the sector's margins.

TRADE-ECONOMY · WSJ

Failure of Australia's largest IPO in decades sends tremors through AI trade

The collapse of Firmus's float, Australia's largest IPO in decades, is sending tremors through the broader AI investment trade, the Wall Street Journal reports, as scrutiny intensifies on the deal's backers.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand exodus to Australia hits 13-year high ahead of election

Net migration of New Zealanders to Australia has hit its highest level in *13 years*, Bloomberg reports, as thousands leave ahead of the November 7 election. The outflow adds pressure to a campaign already centered on jobs and the cost of living.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Rio Tinto says oil price shock favours Australian miners

Rio Tinto says rivals with longer shipping routes are curbing production as higher fuel prices play to Australia's geographic advantage, the AFR reports.

UPCOMING

OCT 21

Kāinga Ora deadline sale of 36 Wellington state homes

Tests whether the government presses ahead with asset sales just weeks before an election that could change housing policy.

OCT 26

Advance voting opens for New Zealand general election

Marks the start of the formal pre-election voting period, after a campaign dominated by foreign aid and migration disputes.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Determines the shape of the next coalition government, with NZ First's Winston Peters a likely kingmaker.

NOV 2026

NZDF polar surveillance drone tender closes

First dedicated Southern Ocean UAV purchase under the 2025-29 Defence Capability Plan, signaling further drone acquisitions.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Devpolicy: Tonga anti-corruption chief on independence 'in practice'

Tonga's Anti-Corruption Commissioner **Mele Fakatouato Mangisi** writes that independence for small-island anti-corruption bodies means more than formal safeguards like the UN Convention against Corruption and the Jakarta Principles, arguing that "everyone knows everyone" in practice shapes how independence actually functions.

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

Hospitality sector warns of worker shortages under migration cuts

Hospitality industry leaders have launched a social media campaign warning that sweeping migration cuts will leave cafes and kitchens short-staffed, ABC News reports, the latest sector pushback against the government's migration policy.

ABC NEWS

University head warns foreign student cuts would cripple research

University of Tasmania Vice-Chancellor **Rufus Black** says slashing international student numbers would cripple research capacity, ABC News reports, warning of reputational damage in Asia amid the government's migration debate.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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